

Sana Afreen

HCI Researcher & Experience Designer

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RESEARCH FOCUS

HCI researcher and experience designer specializing in affective systems: the intersection of behavioral science, trauma-informed design, and interactive narrative. I build research-grounded work for populations that mainstream tools consistently get wrong: neurodivergent users, displaced communities, and survivors of historical and ongoing trauma. Every design decision traces back to research.

EDUCATION

M.S. Human-Computer Interaction | DePaul University, Chicago IL

November 2025

GPA: 3.83 / 4.0

B.S. Information Technology | Jawaharlal Nehru Technological University Hyderabad

RESEARCH METHODS & SKILLS

Research: Semi-Structured Interviews · Contextual Inquiry · Affinity Diagramming · Usability Testing · Heuristic Evaluation · Card Sorting · Tree Testing · Persona Development · Journey Mapping · Empathy Mapping · Task Analysis · A/B Testing · Surveys · Literature Review & Synthesis · Data Synthesis · Statistical Analysis

Frameworks: Self-Determination Theory · Behavioral Scaffolding · Cognitive Load Theory · Affective Computing · ELSI Principles · Trauma-Informed Design · Triadic Game Design

Design: Figma · Wireframing · Prototyping · Interaction Design · Narrative Architecture · Affective Design · Design Systems · Accessibility (WCAG) · Visual Design · User Flows

Tools: Optimal Workshop · UXArmy · Miro · Jira · Twine · Ren'Py · Unity · Blender · HTML · CSS · JavaScript

RESEARCH & DESIGN EXPERIENCE

UX Research Lead | SpellStep — DePaul University Capstone Studio

Sept – Nov 2025

- ❑ Led full mixed-methods research process for a gamified task-initiation app designed for neurodivergent users (ADHD, AuDHD)
- ❑ Conducted 5 semi-structured interviews; synthesized findings into a 6-theme affinity diagram revealing task initiation — not motivation — as the primary barrier
- ❑ Applied Self-Determination Theory to ground all three core feature pillars in cognitive science and behavioral literature
- ❑ Achieved 86.25% task success rate via tree testing (UXArmy); conducted open card sort with 24 cards via Optimal Workshop
- ❑ Iterated through 2 prototype testing rounds; removed a 0%-comprehension feature after Round 2 confirmed it failed across all participants

UX/UI Designer & Narrative Architect | Redress — DePaul University x UCSC History Department

June – Nov 2025

- ❑ Designed a complete Figma UI system for an interactive Twine narrative addressing Japanese American incarceration during WWII
- ❑ Collaborated with historians from UC Santa Cruz to embed archival material into gameplay flow and interface touchpoints
- ❑ Developed wireframes and clickable prototypes for inventory, map, save/load, and codex systems, aligning UI behavior with historical accuracy and narrative pacing
- ❑ Applied accessibility-first design principles across all interface elements

UX/UI Designer & Narrative Systems Architect | Space Odyssey — DePaul University x Chicago Refugee Coalition

April – Nov 2025

- ❑ Designed narrative-first UI systems for a sci-fi visual novel exploring forced migration through the lens of planetary colonization
- ❑ Independently researched forced displacement systems to ground speculative fiction in real-world relevance and strengthen player impact

- Applied narrative taxonomy to structure branching choices, reinforce player agency, and amplify thematic resonance
- Self-taught Twine in under 24 hours to deliver a functional prototype under a high-pressure deadline

UX/UI Designer & 3D Artist | *Boom! Haunted — DePaul University Team Project*

Sept 2025

- Defined game UX flow, player onboarding, and interaction patterns for a comedy-paranormal adventure game
- Created all key NPC 3D characters in Blender using a custom low-poly aesthetic optimized for animation and game-ready rigging
- Wrote comedic dialogue and event scripts shaping game humor, pacing, and character personality
- Collaborated across design, narrative, and engineering to ensure cohesive player experience